TIPS FOR WRITING A FIVE-PARAGRAPH ESSAY

The academic essay is a classic type of text required of university students. In most cases, students are provided a writing prompt and must write an essay on that topic. Essay writing, especially when part of an in-class, timed examination, can be stressful and intimidating for students of all ages. However, if you know what to expect and understand how to write a five-paragraph essay, you will be prepared to tackle any essay writing prompt.

Types of Essays

When you receive an essay prompt, you must first decide what type of essay you are being asked to write. There are many different types of essays, including narrative, reflective, expository, argumentative, comparative, literary, and so on. The essay type will determine how you approach the topic, the type of evidence you use to support your claims, and the organizational pattern. Essays for tests are typically either expository, in which you explain a topic, or argumentative, in which you take a stand on an issue and persuade your reader to accept your claims.

For most essay writing situations, a five-paragraph essay should suffice. The essay should include an introductory paragraph, three supporting paragraphs, and a concluding paragraph.

The First Paragraph: The Introduction

In the first paragraph you will introduce the topic and your main claim or stand on the issue. The introduction is often the most important paragraph because it provides direction for the entire essay. You can use it to grab the reader's attention and set the tone for your piece of writing. The best way to tackle the introduction is to:

- Introduce the topic with a few general statements. Describe relevant background information or both sides of a controversy. The opening should be interesting and move your reader from a general understanding of the topic to more specific ideas related to your main claim.
- Develop a thesis statement. This is the sentence in which you introduce your main claim, or what you want to say about the topic. You can use the essay prompt to help you form this sentence. For example, when the writing prompt is a question, your thesis is typically your answer to the question.
- List three points or arguments that support your thesis in order of importance (one sentence for each). Boil these down into three phrases and incorporate them into your thesis as the controlling ideas for the essay. If putting them all together in one sentence makes the thesis too long, you may put the controlling ideas in a separate sentence. One good reason to list your main points in the introduction is that it provides an outline for your body paragraphs.

The Second, Third, and Fourth Paragraphs: Supporting Details

These three paragraphs form the body of the essay. They provide explanation of the main points or arguments which support your thesis as well as the facts, quotes, examples, and evidence to support these claims. Take the points you listed as the controlling ideas in your thesis statement and discuss each one in a body paragraph. Here is how:

- First, write a topic sentence that summarises your point. This is the first sentence of your paragraph.
- Next, explain why the topic sentence is true.
- Present evidence (facts, quotes, examples, and statistics) to support your argument.

- End with a summary statement that reiterates your topic sentence in slightly different words.

Now you have your first body paragraph. Repeat this procedure for points two and three, using clear transition words or phrases between the paragraphs.

The Fifth Paragraph: The Conclusion
The concluding paragraph brings the essay to a logical end. In your conclusion, you should restate the thesis and briefly summarize your supporting points. Your final sentence should uphold your main idea in a clear and compelling manner by providing a suggestion, opinion or prediction related to the topic. However, be sure you do not present any new claims or arguments in the conclusion.

Parting Thoughts
When preparing to write an essay, start by making an outline in which you write your thesis and list your three main supporting points. Brainstorm evidence and examples to support each of your main points and jot them down in your outline. Then consider what background information your reader needs to understand the topic. Jot these ideas down as notes for the introduction. Once your outline is ready, begin drafting the essay. The time it takes to create an outline is not wasted. In fact, with an outline you will write more efficiently and effectively since you have done the hard work of planning your ideas and the flow of the essay in advance. If you are writing in an exam situation, remember not to get stuck at any one paragraph. If you run out of ideas, move on and try to complete the essay. You will score more points with a complete essay that has a few gaps in one of the paragraphs than you will with an incomplete essay that has a few good paragraphs but not an appropriate ending.

Whether you are writing in an exam situation or for a take-home assignment, there will always be a deadline for your work. Remember to give yourself enough time to re-read and make corrections to your writing before you submit it. Make any revisions that you think will improve your draft and be sure to check for any grammatical or typing errors.

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